

The Things They Carried

The Things They Carried is a book by American author and Vietnam war veteran Tim O'Brien. It was originally published in 1990 by Houghton Mifflin. The story is a collection of fictional stories about an American platoon during the Vietnam war. Although it is fiction it is based on some of his and other soldier's experiences during the war. I personally choose this book because I like to learn about American wars, but one of the ones I know the least about is the Vietnam war. I thought this would be a good book for me to learn a bit more about the war. I thought the book would be about how the soldiers felt during the war and what the things that they carried with them meant to the soldiers. Where the book would switch between several groups or individuals and tell their stories,

Our main character is a soldier named Lieutenant Jimmy Cross, a 24 year old soldier in the US army deployed in Vietnam during the late 60's or early 70's. We learn in the beginning we learn about the things the soldiers carry with them through this war, both tangible and intangible, their weapons and equipment, as well as their burdens. For Cross it is a letter from his love back in the states, a girl named Martha who is described as a poet and full of solitude. For other members of the platoon, like Rat Keily it was comics, Henry Dobbins carried clothing from his girlfriend, or Kiowa a native american protestant carried a new testament and his grandfather's hatchet. We learn about the other weights the soldiers carry, their burdens, like Cross' responsibility to keep his soldier alive. We see how in love cross is, his mind constantly wandering and daydreaming about spending time with her. We also learn about Ted Lavander, a

man who recently died outside a small village when he was shot through the head and collapsed instantly. After that Cross has a mindset change, he convinces himself to let go of Martha and burns her letters, he tells himself he'll be more strict with his soldiers and not let himself daydream anymore. We have a skip in time, to at least 1979 a few years after the war when Cross meets up with a soldier and shares more stories, and what happened between him and Martha after. Then the soldier states that he'll write a book about their time. Our first story is from the author of the book and describes his struggles when he attempts to run away to Canada when he was drafted. We hear about his time with an old man named Elroy and his breakdown and eventual decision to return and go to the war. We learn from Rat about Curt Lemon, his best friend and when he was killed and how it affected and scared him

We learn about Mary Anne, a girl who was deeply changed by Vietnam, even abandoning her life for the war. We learn about the author's first kill in war, how it made him feel, how his experience has scared him. We hear about Norman Bowker, and how he is guilt-ridden by the fact he let another soldier, Kiowa, drown in mud simply because the mud was filled with feces and he ran away. We can tell how not having anyone to talk about makes him feel terrible, to the point where a few years after the war he decides to end his own life after not feeling any meaning in his life. The last large story was about our author again, it is about how he attempted to get revenge on another soldier who almost caused his death when he was shot. He would group up with another soldier and scare him. Eventually he got over it and did learn to reconvene. Another story is about Rat Keily, how he slowly snapped under pressure, going a bit mad and beginning to imagine how his comrades would look dead, before one day deciding to finally end it all.

This is a story from the soldiers, their stories, although not all in the book are true, the author himself stating that “I want you to feel what I felt. I want you to know why story-truth is truer sometimes than happening-truth.”(Tim O’Brien, 171) telling that his stories are partly made up, used to show an emotional truth rather than a factual truth. It's because he believes that that kind of truth is more important to you, he lies and exaggerates to get you to feel how they felt. Of course the stories are at least loosely based on true stories from the author's and other soldiers' stories and experiences in the war, although we don't know how exaggerated they are. The soldiers are all young, and innocent, some in their mid 20s, others barely 18. It's about the horrors and scars and how the wars affected the young men. They don't feel good stories that inspire people, they are more realistic, darker, and more grim. Oftentimes they are gruesome and grizzly giving insight to how it was for the soldiers.

The main point of the book, especially in chapters like “Speaking of courage” is to show how dark war is for the soldiers in the war, how even after battle the war can cost lives. The stories had many themes in them, from Love in chapters like “Love”, to fear in chapters “On the Rainy River” or “The dentist”. But the most flaring themes that many of the stories have is that of how guilt haunts people during, and even after the war, it happens to our narrator, to lieutenant cross, to Norman Bowker. For the narrator it's his kill on a young man, it keeps haunting him, imagining what kind of life he took away from him. For cross it's the lives of the soldiers lost under his watch, those he couldn't save. For Bowker it's the life of his best friend Kiowa who drowned in mud because he was weak, and how the guilt over took him leading him to his own death.

None of the characters in the book have a major role in any kind of big event that took place in the war. None of them were special or famous, they were all just normal foot soldiers

that were drafted for a war that was not their own. Their experiences in the war aren't tales of valor and fame but rather of what one soldier experienced just being there, not even having to do anything special to be scared by what was happening in the war. But I feel like it adds to the message that O'Brien is putting out, that these kinds of experiences weren't rare, they happened to a lot the soldiers who fought in the war, that these tales were an almost universal experience to soldiers and they didn't have to take part in some big event or battle or need to be famous for something to happen to them. It was simply a part of war for the soldiers, their experience that they would have to carry with them forever

The book, although stated to be exaggerated, does seem to have a large amount of it based in true stories, like Cross' or Norman Bowker's who both directly gave permission to write about them. I assume that the other stories from the perspective of the narrator are also based on real events even if stretched and exaggerated from Tim O'Brien's own war time and experiences.

The book left an impact on me, before I had heard war stories but they were just about one person and I guess I just thought that those kinds of stories only happened to some kind of people. But this book helped me realize that these kinds of stories are common among regular soldiers. It brings to light the horrors of war not shying away from graphic and gruesome descriptions of scenes that the soldiers saw, from the young man's exploded and mangled body in "The man I killed" to Kiowa's drowned and sickly body after they pulled him from the mud. I did feel like the book was engaging for me, it was interesting seeing what kind of different experiences characters went through despite being in the same situation. I liked reading about how the characters felt real, not fictional because of the uniqueness the book gave each character. It isn't the most thrilling book I've read, mainly due to the fact that it was mostly Guerilla warfare and not open battlefields, but I don't think that holds it back. This book isn't one that needs

action, after all it isn't about the war itself rather about the people in it, and to understand the characters I don't need action for it.

The book did teach me a little about the war, although because it was limited to the perspective of one platoon, what was mentioned was limited. It taught me a few background details on the war, like how when the draft was called a large number of young men escaped into Canada to avoid it. It reinforced the horrors I knew happened on the battlefields and gave me another reason to not want to go to war.

Personally I would say that if you don't mind the war setting and gore described in it then it's worth a read. I think it offers a good insight into how war was for the soldiers participating. Its stories are interesting and the characters fun, and there is even some humor in it although it is a bit twisted. It's not a long book and every chapter is a place where you could pause reading so it makes for a good reading experience. It also has a free audio 6 hour book on youtube if you don't feel like reading it all. I think it makes for a good read and is worth your time .